

DIGITAL CITIZENSHIP MINI LESSON · GRADES 3–6

My digital footprint

Every game, app, video, and AI chatbot a kid uses leaves footprints — not on the ground, but on a screen somewhere. This ten-minute lesson makes an invisible idea visible, then hands students a habit that works on anything with a login, including AI.

THE BIG IDEA

If it's typed, tapped, or searched, it can leave a footprint somewhere.
Some footprints fade fast. Some don't. Act like they don't.

Teach it (5 minutes, read aloud or in your own words)

Ask: "If you walked across wet sand, would there be a footprint after you walked away?" Yes — for a while, until the tide comes in. Now ask: "What about typing your name into a search bar, or asking an AI chatbot a question?" That can leave a footprint too — but it might not fade like sand does. Some websites and apps keep a record of what you typed for a long time, even after you close the tab.

That doesn't mean the internet is scary. It means we leave footprints on purpose, the way we'd choose our path across sand — not every step, everywhere, without thinking.

Sort it: footprint or not?

Read each one aloud. Thumbs up if it leaves a footprint, thumbs down if it doesn't.

Does this leave a digital footprint?	Footprint?
Typing your full name into a website's sign-up form	Yes
Asking a search engine a question	Yes
Thinking about a question in your head	No
Typing a question into an AI chatbot	Yes
Talking to a friend at recess, out loud	No
Posting a comment or a photo online	Yes
Writing in a paper journal you keep at home	No

Activity: green light, red light

GREEN LIGHT — OKAY TO SHARE

A username you made up · your favorite color · a game score · a question about how something works

RED LIGHT — KEEP IT OFFLINE

Your full name and address · your school's name · a photo of your face · your birthday and age together

Have students sort five more examples of their own into green light / red light — then check each other's work. Disagreements are the best part of this activity.

The rule to remember

Before you type it, ask: "Would I want a stranger to have this?" If yes, it's probably fine. If no, leave it out — or ask a grown-up first. This same rule works for search engines, games, apps, and AI chatbots.

Talk about it

- **"What's one footprint you've left today, without thinking about it?"** Most kids can name three or four once they start looking.
- **"Does a footprint ever go away?"** Some fade, some don't — the honest answer is "you often can't tell which," so it's safer to assume it sticks.
- **"What would you want a stranger to *not* know about you?"** That list is the one worth protecting most.

Ten minutes now, revisited whenever a new app or AI tool comes up — the habit generalizes to anything with a login.

Keep going: our free Internet Safety with AI one-pager and "Is It True?" fact-checking lesson build on this same habit. Both in our TpT store.

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